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FUNDAMENTALS OF MANAGEMENT AND ORGANIZATIONAL BEHAVIOR

Week 13 – Managing Communication

MNT 215 – Summer 2026

Suliman S. Olayan School of Business | American University of Beirut



Slides partly adapted from Robbins, S. P., Coulter, M. A. & Long, L. K. (2024). Management (16th Global Edition).



WHAT IS COMMUNICATION?

- **Communication:** the transfer and understanding of meaning
- **Interpersonal communication:** communication between two or more people
- **Organizational communication:** all the patterns, networks, and systems of communication within an organization



FORMAL VERSUS INFORMAL

- **Formal communication:** communication that takes place within prescribed organizational work arrangements
- **Informal communication:** communication that is not defined by the organization's structural hierarchy



FUNCTIONS OF COMMUNICATION

- Management
- Motivation
- Emotional sharing
- Persuasion
- Information exchange

Part 1. Interpersonal Communication



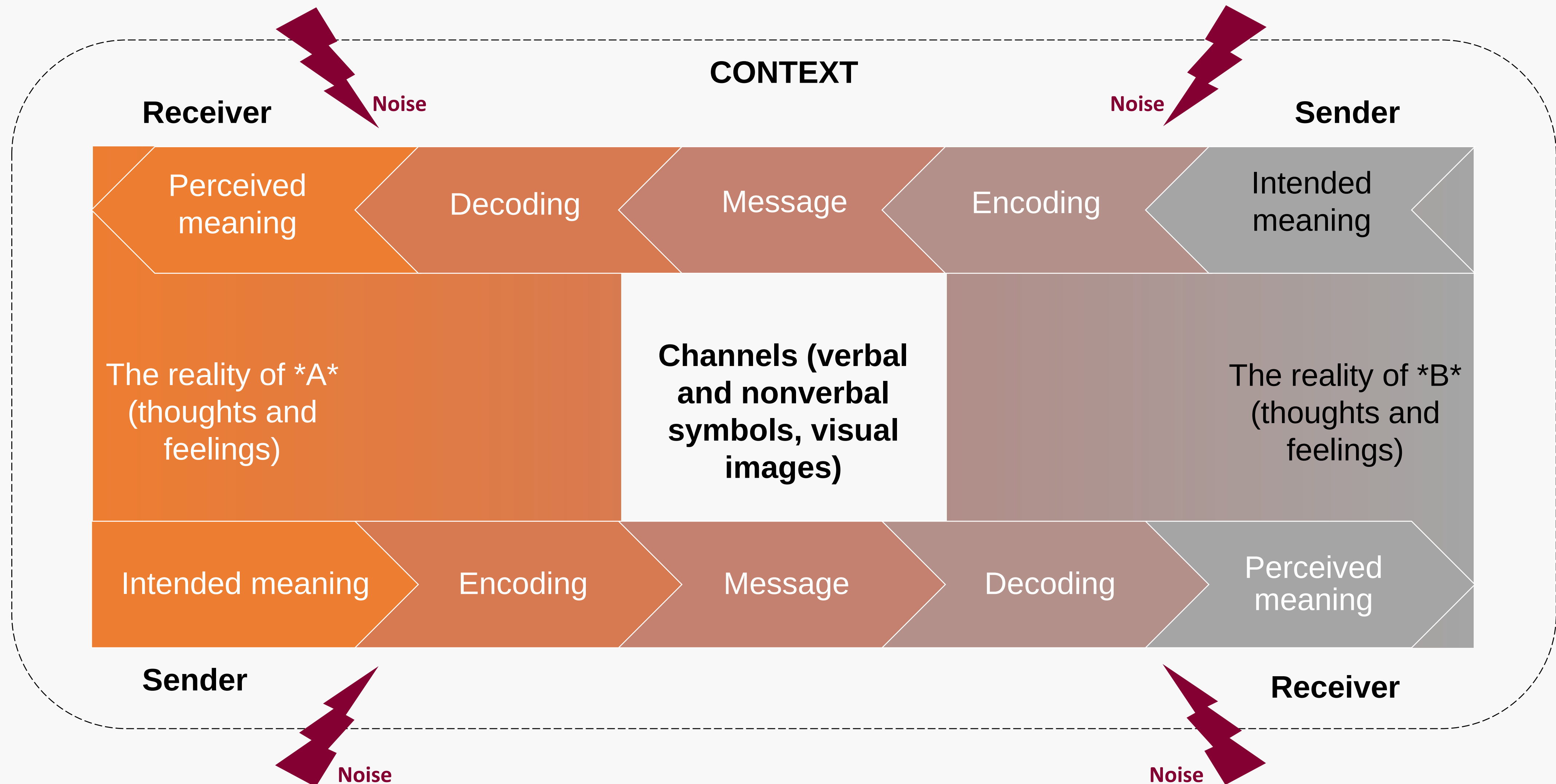
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THE COMMUNICATION PROCESS





MODES OF COMMUNICATION

- Oral communication
- Written communication
- Nonverbal communication



NONVERBAL COMMUNICATION

- **Nonverbal communication:** communication transmitted without words
 - **Body language:** gestures, facial configurations, and other body movements that convey meaning
 - **Verbal intonation:** an emphasis given to words or phrases that conveys meaning



BARRIERS

- **Information overload:** when information exceeds our processing capacity
- **Filtering:** the deliberate manipulation of information to make it appear more favorable to the receiver
- **Jargon:** specialized terminology or technical language that members of a group use to communicate among themselves



ADDITIONAL BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION

- Emotions
- Silence
- National culture

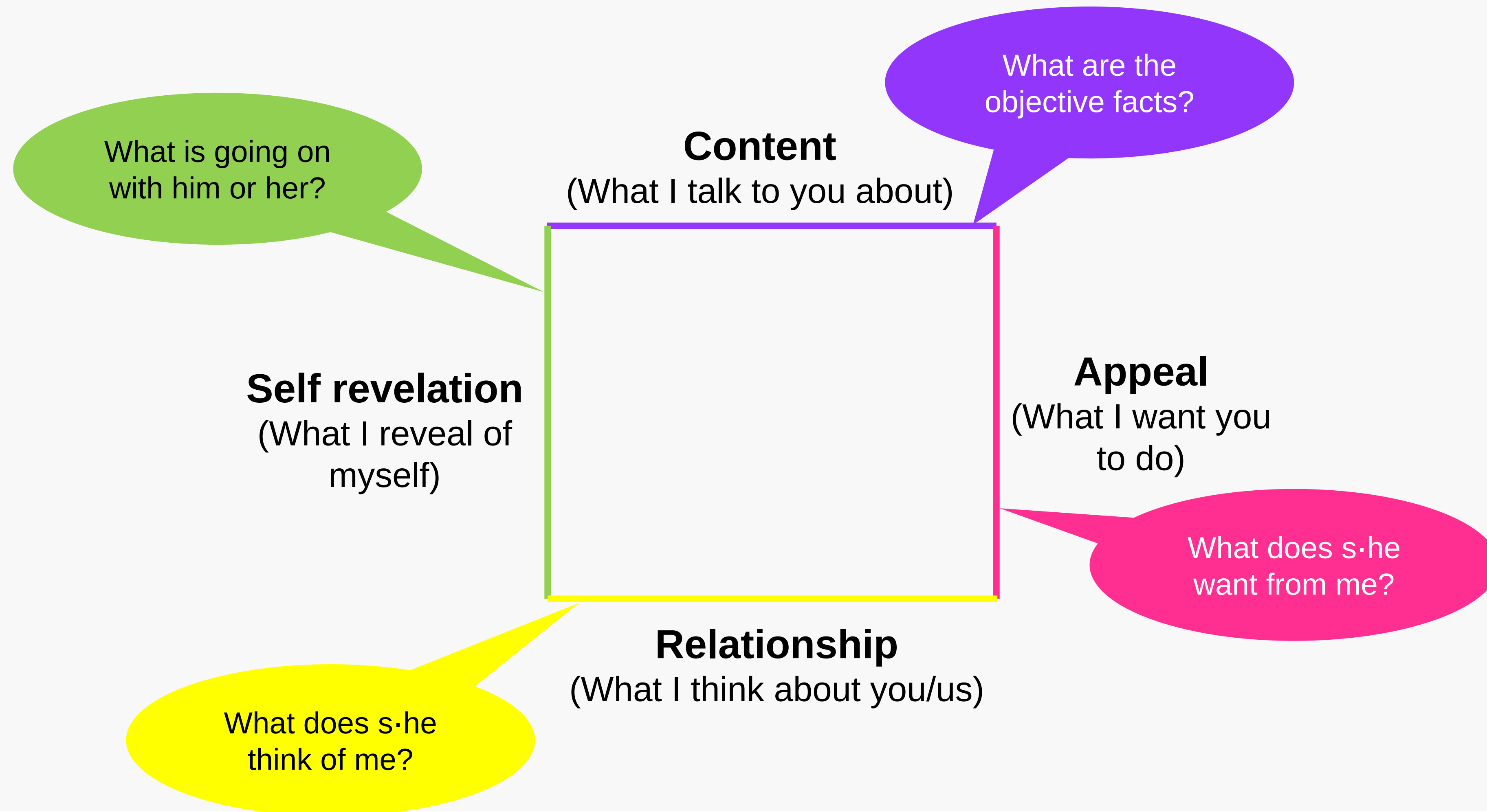


OVERCOMING THE BARRIERS

- Use feedback
- Simplify language
- Listen actively
 - **Active listening:** listening for full meaning without making premature judgments or interpretations
- Constrain emotions
- Watch nonverbal cues



THE COMMUNICATION SQUARE: A TOOL TO BETTER COMMUNICATE





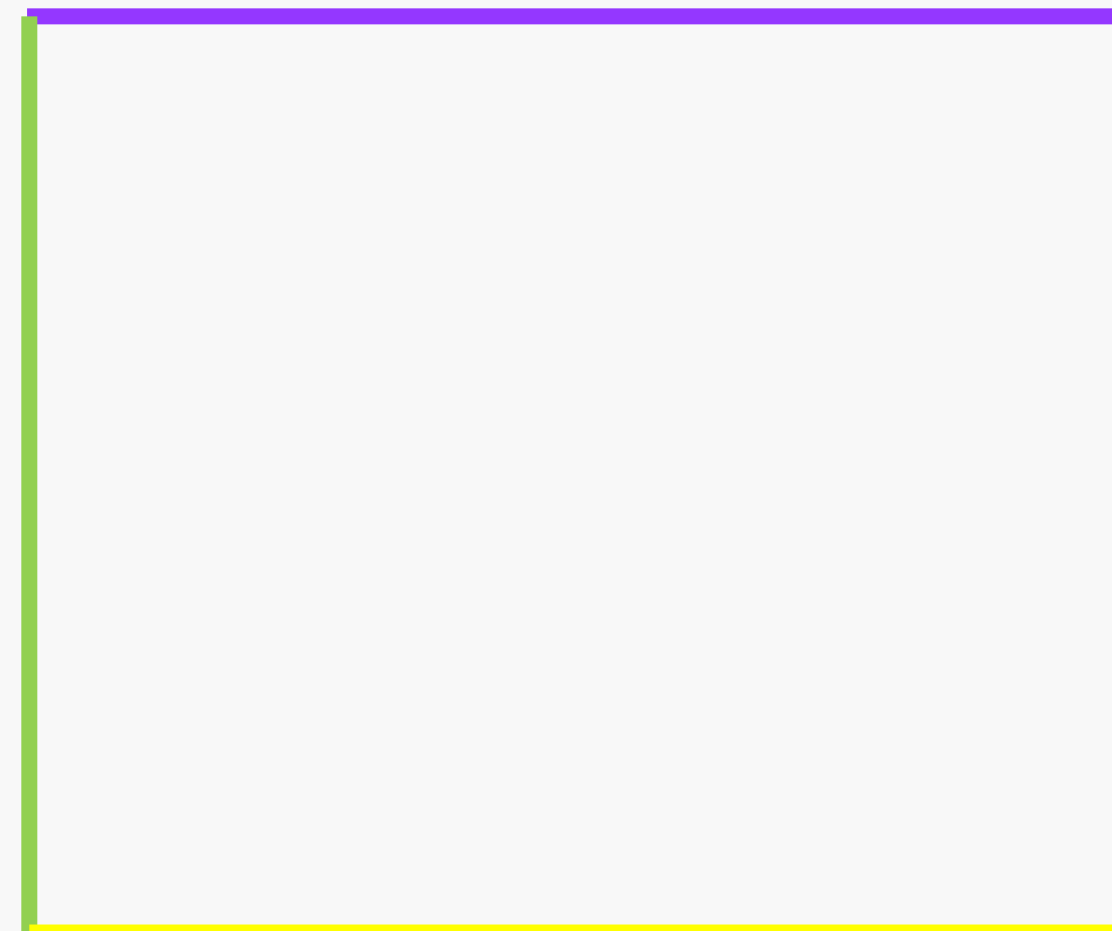
THE COMMUNICATION SQUARE: TYPICAL STRENGTHS AND WEAKNESSES OF THE FOUR “EARS”

Self revelation

- + empathetic, understanding
- shift problems to others, doesn't question him/herself

Content

- + factual, neutral, result-oriented, objective, unsusceptible
- blind to emotional nuances, impersonal



Appeal

- + cooperative, obliging, goal-oriented
- will be exploited, little focus on own needs

Relationship

- + sensitive, reads between the lines, human
- vulnerable, easily hurt or angry, takes everything personally



THE COMMUNICATION SQUARE: PREPARE FOR AN IMPORTANT CONVERSATION

Content

- Which topics do I want to address?
- What are my arguments, reasons, examples?

Self revelation

- How do I feel about the situation?
- What are my needs?
- What do I like to share?

Appeal

- What do I want to achieve?
- What is my (min/max) goal?

Relationship

- How will the other feel treated?
- How can I create or maintain a positive relationship?

Part 2. Organizational Communication



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DIRECTION OF FLOW (1 OF 2)

- **Downward:** communication that flows downward from a manager to employees
- Typical communication between a supervisor and employees that report to them



DIRECTION OF FLOW (2 OF 2)

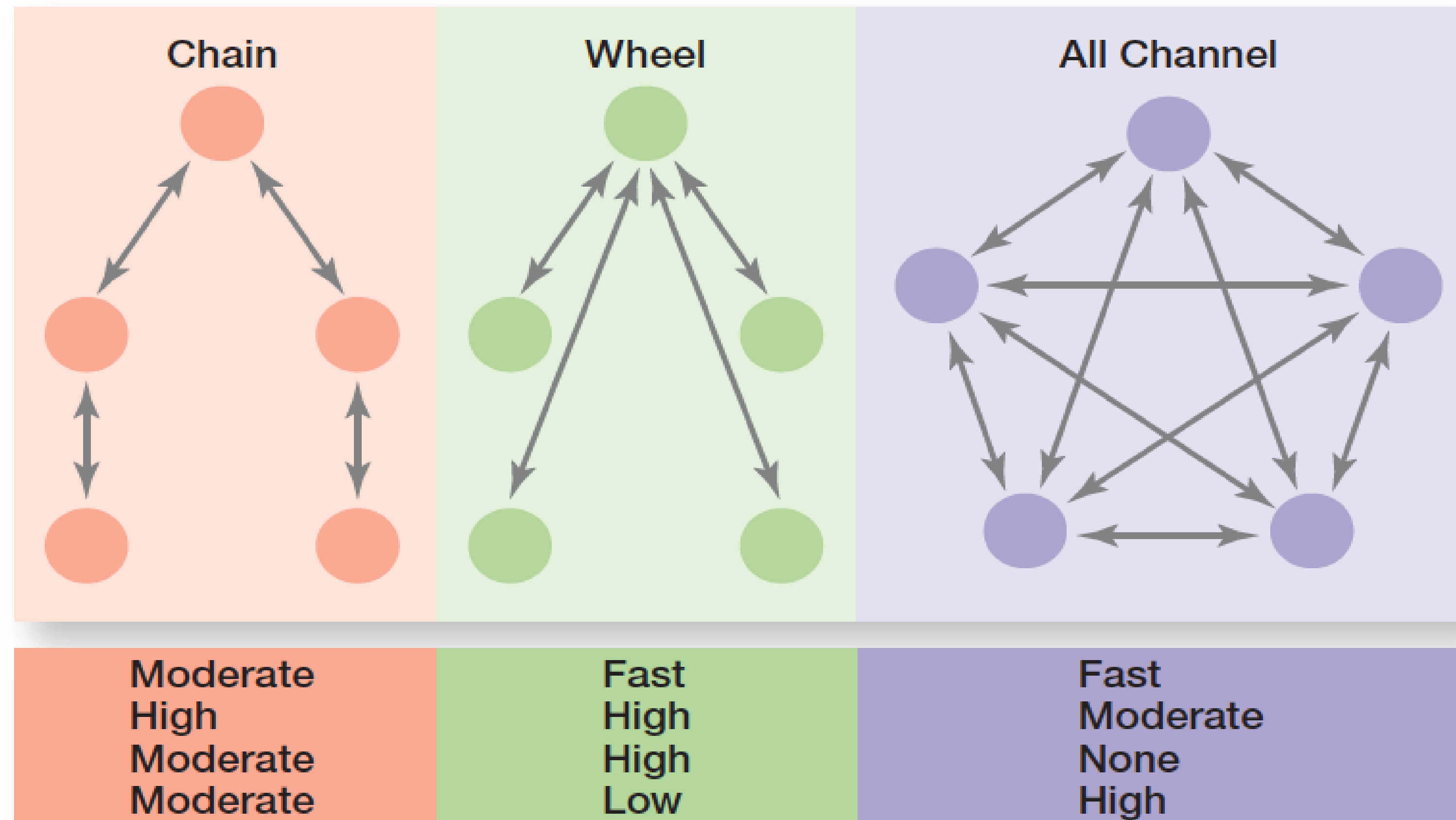
- **Upward communication:** communication that flows upward from employees to managers
- **Lateral communication:** communication that takes place among any employees on the same organizational level
- **Diagonal communication:** communication that cuts across work areas and organizational levels



NETWORKS

- **Communication networks:** the variety of patterns of vertical and horizontal flows of organizational communication
- **Grapevine:** the informal organizational communication network

ORGANIZATIONAL COMMUNICATION NETWORKS



Part 3. Communication & YOU



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SHARPENING YOUR PERSUASION SKILLS

Persuasion skills: skills that enable a person to influence others to change their minds or behavior

- Four of the most basic elements in successful persuasion are:
 1. Be clear about the “who,” “what,” and “why”
 2. Keep it simple
 3. Think about the other person’s needs, motivation, and interests when you shape your argument
 4. Appeal to the “head” and “heart” by combining both rational and emotional arguments.



SHARPENING YOUR SPEAKING SKILLS

- **Speaking skills:** skills that refer to the ability to communicate information and ideas in talking so others will understand
- You will likely notice the following characteristics in effective speakers:
 - Authenticity
 - Humility
 - Brevity
 - A clear understanding of the audience



SHARPENING YOUR WRITING SKILLS

- **Writing skills:** skills that entail communicating effectively in text as appropriate for the needs of the audience
- Some rules that can help you to write simply include:
- **Think before you write.** Focus on what you want to say before you start writing.
- **Be direct.** Get to the point quickly.
- **Cut the fat.** Eliminate unnecessary words.
- **Avoid jargon and grandiose language.** Strive for clarity rather than to impress.
- **Be professional.** Formal communications and reports are different from emails, text messages, and social media comments. This is not the place for abbreviations, acronyms, or textspeak.

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THANK YOU



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